is discussed in the following chapter.

At this point in proceedings, Oleg Troyanovsky, Khrushchev's foreign policy aide, took a phone call from the Foreign Ministry. Dobrynin's report of his meeting with Robert Kennedy had arrived. Troyanovsky took notes and then read them to the Presidium. Don Munton has argued that as the information from Dobrynin arrived before a decision was taken, it could still have informed the Presidium's thinking.[70] Yet, there is no evidence of any hesitation in agreeing Khrushchev's arguments. Nikita had himself already made clear that 'In order to save the world, we must retreat.'

In hindsight, Kennedy could simply have ignored Khrushchev's demands to remove the missiles from Turkey, just as, in hindsight, he could have stopped worrying that Khrushchev would respond to the blockade with action against West Berlin. Hindsight, of course, is a wonderful vantage point, where historians need to tread with great care, and to where political leaders are not granted access.

On the morning of Sunday, 28 October 1962, as John F. Kennedy was setting off for mass at St Stephen's Church on Pennsylvania Avenue, McGeorge Bundy broke the news that Khrushchev was withdrawing the missiles from Cuba. There is no record of what Kennedy said to God, or (or should such a deity exist) what God said to Kennedy. In his later years, Winston Churchill came to fear that humankind had been abandoned by its maker.[71] In October 1962, at least, Winston must have assumed he was still on board with the project.